Ram, Angad, and Hanuman. Ratnasena, in true heroic Kshatriya style, dies magnificently on the battlefield, trying to defend his father's kingdom. Ratnasena, in fact, did not die fighting the Mughals in this battle but died some years later, fighting *for* the Mughals. The *Ratnabhavani* shows us how, as the world began to reconfigure itself in the 1570s, a proud Bundela clan tried to reconcile itself to a new order. In the words of Busch, the text demonstrated 'the fervent wish that the Mughals could be resisted in the face of a new historical reality where resistance is no longer possible'.

By the time Keshavdas wrote his second historical poem, the *Virsimhdevcarit*, twenty-five years later, the political landscape had altered considerably. The pejorative term 'mleccha' was no longer acceptable and the words Pathan and Turk no longer evoked the alienating 'otherness' they had in the *Ratnabhavani*. Raja Madhukar Shah had died in 1592 and Akbar had recognized the right to his position of his eldest son, Ram Shah. However, the raja's youngest son, Bir Singh Deo, contested this claim and spent a decade skirmishing with his brother and with the Mughal forces. It is Bir Singh Deo's rise to power that the *Virsimhdevcarit* celebrates but the events it would gloss over were scandalous and would involve the murder of one of Akbar's beloved friends and would implicate Prince Salim.

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*Orchestra.

† Tour guides and local priests today still claim the temple's superstructure was deliberately destroyed.

*A tradition of early Hindi literature, associated with the late medieval court.